



Sony's BDP-S350 Blu-ray player

is provided on the front side of the DVD player so that it's easy for you to access.

Disk capacity. The DVD player should be able to play both single- and double-layer DVDs (4.7GB and 9GB).

Disk formats. Latest DVD players can play CD-DA (which is an Audio CD format), CD-R/CD-RW, Video CD/SVCD, DVD, DVD-R/-RW, DVD+R/+RW and DVD-Video.

Playback formats. Generally, a DVD player is capable of playing MP3, JPEG files (photos) in addition to DVD-Video, VCD and Audio CD. However, there are DVD players available in India with much more versatile playability. These players can play DivX files and WMA (Windows Media Audio) formats. Some even play WMV (Windows Media Video). Go for a DVD player that gives you these options, so you can play more music and video formats downloaded from the Web.

Picture control. A DVD player needs to control the picture elements. Smart picture controls include choice between soft, bright and cool/warm picture display, but more important are picture enhancement tools like zoom, flip and rotate, which are useful for picture CD viewing.

Surround sound. As explained earlier, most DVD players with surround sound come with 5.1-channel connectivity (six pins) for sound.

Almost all the DVD players with 5.1-channel connectivity come with a Dolby Digital surround decoder. Having surround sound decoding built into your DVD player can be very useful, especially if you have a Dolby Digital receiver and at least six speakers to achieve the 5.1 surround sound effect.

There are some players that can even decode the DTS surround sound. You will need to pay little bit more for them but can enjoy the DTS surround effect at home. Needless to say, whether Dolby or DTS, you need to have a



Videocon's VAD10SNN DVD player

disk with 5.1 surround soundtracks (Dolby or DTS).

Navigation. Take time in the store to turn on the DVD player and navigate the menus. The navigation must be intuitive and smooth. Philips DVD players let you get to your movie faster rather than spending time on the menus. If you can use the menu without requiring the user manual, it implies that the navigation is good.

Built-in amplifier. This is an additional feature that helps to enhance the audio output. If you're in the habit

of listening to audio tracks rather than watching movies, a DVD player with a built-in amplifier is a better choice. In fact, there are few DVD players with built-in speaker. Just keep in mind to buy a good brand.

Remote control. The remote control should be easy to hold and operate. It should have buttons that are well-marked, clearly and logically grouped, and easy to operate.

FM radio. If you go for a DVD player with FM, check whether it can play without television connectivity. The reason is that it would be troublesome to switch the TV for FM listening and the power consumed by the TV is very high. Also ensure that the DVD player stores station presets so you don't have to tune them again and again.

Power consumption. Look for a

DVD player with power consumption as low as 10 watts (less than a night lamp) and low standby power.

Display. DVD players today come with either LCD or 7-segment displays. Make sure you purchase one with a display rather than without a display. This is quite useful when you want to use it without TV, such as when listening to music.

Last but not the least

Choose what is best for your viewing requirement and budget. The time seems to be right to move towards a Blu-ray player, which is the next big technology in playback. Any TV that has at least Composite video inputs can work with a Blu-ray player but to enjoy the superior picture clarity of a Blu-ray, you need to use the HDMI connectivity, which is widely available only in LCD and plasma TVs. ●

Pioneer's BDP-51FD Blu-ray player



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